Important Update

2026-09-14 00:00:00

On September 14, 2026, the U.S. District Court for the District of Massachusetts issued an order pausing the effective date of the Department of Homeland Security's Duration of Status Final Rule while litigation concerning the rule continues.

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Guidelines for Maintaining Status

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Following U.S. Laws and Immigration Requirements

While international students are in the United States, they are subject to all federal, state and local laws that govern U.S. citizens. They are also subject to immigration laws, which define and limit their activities as nonimmigrants.

Failure to comply with immigration laws can jeopardize an individual's immigration status and result in a request for voluntary departure or removal from the United States by the U.S. Department of Homeland Security.

Under the immigration laws of the United St n as "aliens," are expected to meet certain standards of be sible Aliens and 8 USC 1227: Deportable Aliens of the Im ose standards may render them ineligible for vis o removal.

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ples of actions that may trigger inadmi nc

- Activities that promote or involve violence or destruction of property.

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Minimum unit requirements by degree level:

Degree Level	Minimum Number of Units Required
Undergraduate students	12
Master's graduate students	8
Graduate certificate students	8
PhD graduate students	
Master's/PhD graduate students with an assistantship	

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Online Course Load Limitations

Exceptions to Course Load Rules

Thesis/Dissertation Submission Timeline and Enrollment Requirements

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Maintaining Valid Immigration Documents

I-20 or DS-2019

Passports

I-94

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Change of Local Address

All noncitizens living in the United States must report any change of address within 10 days of moving. For students in F-1 or J-1 status — including those on OPT, STEM OPT or Academic Training — all address changes should be made by updating their contact information and address via both the SEVIS U.S. Address and Contact Update Form in Trojan International and Experience USC. Trojan International updates your address in SEVIS, and Experience USC updates your address with the registrar's office at USC.

Graduated students on OPT, STEM OPT or Academic Training Extension must update their addresses in Trojan International to ensure their SEVIS record stays up to date.

Students must enter their U.S. address in the correct format for their information to be updated in SEVIS. Here are some tips for entering your U.S. address:

- The "street address" field can only contain a street number and street name (for example, 2700 Ellendale).
- The "apartment, suite, etc." field can on or Unit 5) and is applicable to students living in ar If you live in a house, leave this field blank.
- Enter a five-digit code into the "zip/post nd can be omitted.

Enter the city's name and zip code accura

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not eligible for a grace period.

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Academic Suspension, Expulsion or Dismissal

F-1 or J-1 international students are required to register for a full course of study in classes that meet their degree requirements during the fall and spring semesters. Students who are unable to maintain this requirement due to a suspension or expulsion from the university or dismissal from their academic program are at risk of falling out of their F-1 or J-1 status, ultimately affecting their eligibility to legally remain in the United States.

Academic suspensions, expulsions and dismissals are considered serious F-1 or J-1 status violations and can affect future U.S. visa applications and benefits. Students in this situation should contact an OIS advisor immediately to discuss their options.

Appeals

SEVIS Termination

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